EXPLAINER

How the SPASD Budget Works

From a meeting with the district's Director of Business & Finance · August 18, 2026

The short version: the district's money mostly pays for people, the amount it gets depends on how many students enroll, and Wisconsin's per-student funding hasn't kept up with inflation.

Topic	What I learned
Biggest cost	About 80% of spending is staff. The rest covers busing, supplies, and utilities.
Revenue	Driven by enrollment through state formulas. Revenue must equal expenses.
Budget calendar	Built over 8–9 months, starting in February, adopted in October.
Long-term plan	A 5-year forecast is updated every February.
2024 referendum	$25 million passed; about $7 million went to staff pay after a wage study.
Savings	Fund balance is about 21%. Around 15–20% is considered healthy.
Federal Title grants	About $160,000 less than last year. These fund the highest-need schools.
Special education	The state covers roughly 30% of actual cost; general funds cover the rest.

The most common misunderstanding

Many people assume more state aid means more money for schools. Under Wisconsin's revenue limit, the district can only collect a set amount. More state aid mostly lowers the local property tax levy instead of raising the total.

Biggest risks ahead

- Per-student funding not tied to inflation
- Enrollment projected to decline, partly due to housing costs
- Possible operating deficit down the road as costs rise

How to follow along

- Watch Board of Education meetings and the annual public budget meeting each fall
- Talk to the student representatives on the Board
- Tell state lawmakers how school funding affects your school

Independent and student-led. Written by Zackary Mark, a high school student in the Sun Prairie Area School District. Not an official SPASD document and does not speak for the district, its staff, or its Board. Shared in good faith; not meant to accuse

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